

Toshiba Portégé 3500

Near perfect

Toshiba Portégé 3500 was one of the first devices to feature the Tablet Edition of Windows XP Professional. At first glance, this device looks exactly like a small notebook. Don't be fooled by its looks though—the 12.1-inch screen can be rotated 180 degrees and folded flat on top of the keyboard to activate the Tablet mode.



As far as hardware specs go, this baby sports a Pentium III 1.3 GHz mobile processor, 256 MB SDRAM, a 40 GB hard drive, 12.1-inch Poly-Silicon TFT colour display supporting up to 16 million colours at 1024 x 768, Trident graphics controller, Ali M1535 integrated software sound, inbuilt speakers and microphone. Input options include an 84-key keyboard with 12 function keys, integrated touchpad, a tablet pen with hovering feature and four hardware buttons.

Tipping the scales at less than 2 Kgs, the Portégé 3500 measures 11.6 x 9.2 x 1.2 inches and sports a standard matte black body with elegant silver touchpad, swivel strip and the pivot at the base of the screen. The stylus is located in the screen bezel and pops out when pressed. The unit lacks an optical device—Toshiba should have bundled an external CD-ROM device.

The keyboard is quite sturdy, and the keys well spaced out and comfortable to use. The viewing angle of the LCD screen is quite narrow by normal standards—you need to keep the screen straight to view the colours and text properly.

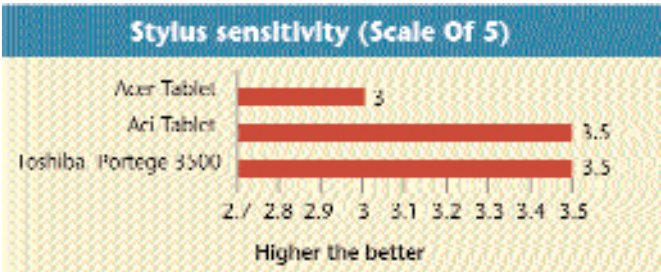
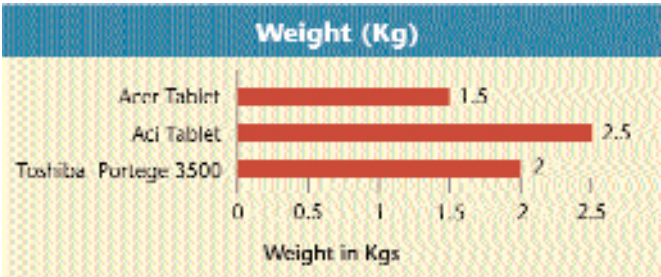
The fun begins when you switch to tablet mode. The display orientation automatically changes to portrait mode. It has handwriting and speech recognition, with an input window for this available on-demand, docked at the bottom of the screen. A tap of the stylus onto the touch sensitive screen is a single-click and a double-tap is a double-click. A small button on the stylus has to be pressed when tapping, to get a right-click. Handwriting recognition is fairly accurate, though a user will require some time to get used to it. Speech recognition, on the other hand, is not very accurate and you may come up with some really funny results.

The Portégé 3500 churns out a decent performance. Most scores returned by this tablet indicate that it is a decent business application device, and will get most of your work done, but don't expect the same for games—it isn't meant to be one. The battery life of around 2 hours may fall short of your requirements.

As far as the price tag is concerned, at Rs 2,04,999, the Portégé 3500 is definitely expensive. Yet the price tag may not be a limiting factor for a hotshot executive on the move, and for those who recognise the need for this kind of functionality. The price, however, needs to drop drastically for it to be accepted by others.

Price: Rs 2,04,999
+ Elegant looks
- Very expensive

Toshiba Portégé 3500 C-	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Usability	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶



Conclusion

The laptop market is just opening up with the introduction of notebooks costing below Rs 60,000, and under such circumstances a Tablet PC that cost Rs 1,50,000 upwards is still too niche a product to be in mass demand. Microsoft's support to this technology has certainly helped it to grow, but sustaining this growth over a longer period of time looks doubtful. Tablets are good devices, marrying the ease of use of a handheld to the capabilities of a laptop, but the trade off does not work all the time. Some models come with passive stylii—a simple plastic stick. Certain other tablet systems come with active stylii that have buttons so that you can make mouse clicks with them. The tablet mode is ideal for usage in workplaces such as hospitals, assembly-line plants, etc., that require you to be constantly on the move and take notes, simultaneously. These laptops that can be converted into tablets as and when you need them that way have their own sets of build quality problems. This arises due to the mechanical complexity of the turnable LCD panel that folds flat for the tablet.

The touch-sensitive LCD screen is a fragile piece of hardware and needs to be handled with care. Mishandling or rough use might damage its sensitivity to touch. Repairing it is a costly affair that you would not like to get involved in.

We managed to get three tablets, from three different vendors, and that too priced drastically different from each other. This was the reason we decided to go without a comparison between them. The most expensive of the lot—Toshiba Portégé 3500 exuded class and elegance. The build quality was top class, and devoid of any flaws, except for the compromised ergonomics omnipresent to any convertible tablet. The Portégé 3500 was amongst the first few tablets that came around, and hence the hardware is pretty out dated by today's standards; yet this wasn't a hindrance with its performance. The configuration should be improved with the launch of the next model.

The Acer tablet came with better hardware and performed significantly better than the Toshiba, but it comes no where near the latter in aesthetic appeal. The Toshiba Portégé 3500 closely emulated the qualities that a tablet PC should possess. As for the ACi tablet, the less said the better.